Three Things Families Assume After a Medicaid Approval, and a Better Habit for Each

What each one looks like, why it happens, and the habit that helps.

After an approval, most families assume the same three things. Every one of them is understandable, and none means you've done anything wrong. Each has a habit that helps.

1 Assuming the approval means the process is finished

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE The letter says approved, everyone exhales, and it goes into the drawer with the application copies. The next envelope from the agency sits on the counter with the catalogs, because the answer was already yes.

WHY IT HAPPENS For months the goal was the approval, and nobody said there was anything after it. But states are required to look again at eligibility through periodic renewals, and the state's letters are how it tells a family whether a form or other information is needed. [1] [2]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Give the Medicaid mail one home and one person who opens it. Copy down every date a letter mentions, and make sure the agency has a current mailing address and phone number for letters about Mom. The federal renewal flyer puts the habit in three lines: update your address, watch your mail, take action. [2]

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2 Assuming Mom's situation will stay the way the application described it

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE Mom moves to a different room, her pension goes up a little, a small check arrives from an old insurance policy. Each one looks like ordinary life, and nobody writes it down.

WHY IT HAPPENS Each change is small, and there is plenty else to think about. But the application described one moment. The nonprofit Justice in Aging notes that changes in a person's life, such as moving or a rise in income, can change their Medicaid eligibility, and that states have procedures for people to report changes in circumstances. [1]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Keep one running list: what changed, the date, and who told you. Don't decide whether it has to be reported. Bring the list to the Medicaid agency or your Medicaid planner and ask. If the change is money arriving, or a plan to give, sell or move something, ask your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney before anything is done. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's guide for people managing a relative's money says to get legal advice and be very careful about decisions that may affect a person's eligibility for Medicaid. [3]

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3 Assuming the paperwork ended with the application

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE The application folder goes up on a shelf. Later a form arrives asking for statements, and nobody is sure where they are or whose job this is now.

WHY IT HAPPENS The application took so many documents that it's natural to think the agency has everything it will ever need. A practice tip written for advocates by the National Center on Law and Elder Rights explains that states are meant to use the data they already have first, and to send forms and requests for documents when that isn't enough. So a request can still arrive. [4]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Keep the record going, and name one person who keeps it. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's guide suggests a list of what is received and spent with dates and reasons, and receipts even for small expenses. Add the statements as they arrive, and a copy of anything you send the agency with the date you sent it. When a letter asks for something and you aren't sure what it wants, ask the agency or your Medicaid planner. [3]

The one habit behind all three

Open it, write it down with the date, and ask the person it belongs to before deciding what it means.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what Mom's state requires, which changes have to be reported, or what to do with money or property, and nothing in it is legal, financial or tax advice. It names three assumptions, the same three the Medicaid Planning Roadmap sees at this step, and a habit for each.

Ready for the next step?

You know which three assumptions to turn into questions. The planning interview is the next step from here: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to your Medicaid planner, or to any other conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The statements about renewals, the state's letters, changes in circumstances and record-keeping come from the sources below, as does the advice to get legal advice first. The three assumptions are the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own.

1. Justice in Aging, Final Rule to Streamline Access to Medicaid
2. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS), Have Medicaid or CHIP? Get ready to renew your coverage
3. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Managing someone else's money: Help for agents under a power of attorney
4. National Center on Law and Elder Rights (Administration for Community Living), Responding to Common Medicaid Unwinding Issues for Dual Eligibles

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